

From Wannabe To Legend

Gear for that tough journey

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The gob-smacking success of Nick Park's *Wallace and Gromit* movies is probably the strongest argument for anyone to try their hand at their own home-made creation at least once, especially now that you have technology on your side. Have you ever watched a movie and thought, "Ooh I want to do that!"

Recent advances in technology, and more importantly the increasing affordability thereof have given us a gaggle of options to showcase our creativity. Fancy yourself as the next big movie director or special effects artist? Grab that shopping basket!

Starry, Starry Eyes

In the beginning, there was the VHS camera. It sat upon the shoulders of the strong, weakening them, and the shoulders of the weak, near-killing them. Then Sony said, "Let there be the HandyCam!" And there was still the VHS camera, but at least now you could hold it in one hand without crippling yourself. And thus began the age of the Home Movie. Suddenly dwellings went from being just house to art house, and everyone loved the camera, even if it hated them.

As all things analogue were doomed to, video went digital too. The big DV (that's Digital Video) has invaded our lives in a bigger way than VHS could ever have hoped. For one thing, you can store movies from your DV camcorder onto your PC, and thanks to Windows XP, you can even turn to small-time movie editing using Windows Movie Maker which comes free with XP.

The Sony HDR - HC1

No video enthusiast can resist the temptations of High Definition (HD)

video. The size, the crispness, the capability to kill entry-level PCs, mmm...

Sony's HDR-HC1 is the world's smallest and lightest HD camcorder, and as with all Sony camcorders, this one is very drool-worthy. Weighing in at just a tad heavier than their lightest camcorders, it captures video in all its vivid glory. Of course, if you're going to edit the movies this one creates, you'd better juice up your PC—editing HD will take a big bite out of your system's resources.

Price: \$1,999 (Rs 85,000)

Shutterbug

While nearly all camcorders come with the ability to take still images as well, they still pose no threats to our much loved digital cameras. When digital photography was first introduced, it tried hopelessly to match up to the quality of the traditional film camera, and no *real* photographer would admit to even touching one. All that's changed now—with 8-megapixel cameras littered all over the markets, digital photography has finally given film something to worry about, to say the least.

High end photography is finding its way into our mobile phones, too. Samsung has been quite aggressive in this area—they showed off a 7-megapixel phone when 1.3 megapixels were a big deal, and at CeBIT 2006, they unveiled the SCH-B600—a 10-megapixel camera-phone!

The Cybershot DSC-R1

Sony's DSC-R1 is the perfect meeting ground between the digital SLR and the point-and-shoot camera. It gives you a real-time preview of the shot you're taking, unlike other digital SLRs, and sports a 10.3-megapixel CMOS sensor. A 2-inch LCD lets you frame your shots nicely, and its considerable weight will